

NW. Africa

Timgad

A magnificent colonial city exemplifying the grid design used in Roman urban planning

Preserved by centuries of burial in Saharan sand, the ruins of Timgad in the Aurès mountains of present-day Algeria are sometimes referred to as the Algerian Pompeii. Although sacked by invaders in the 5th and 8th centuries, the foundations of the Roman walled city have survived, along with some of the original structures, and the site today shows the sophistication of Roman town planning at its height.

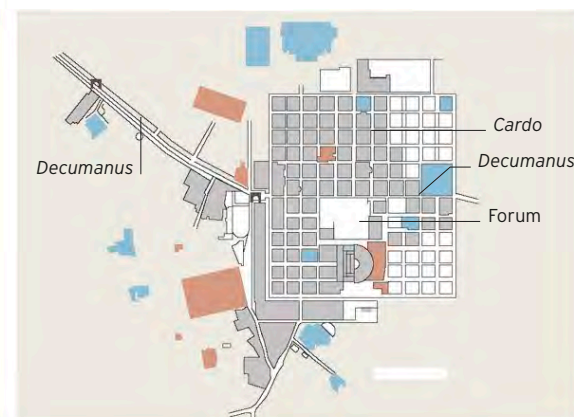
Limestone city

Timgad was founded in about 100 CE by the Roman Emperor Trajan, probably as a residence for troops defending the Roman colony in Numidia from Berber attack. Working on a site where there had been no previous settlement, the city's planners had free reign and an opportunity to design a city on a strictly regular grid. Local limestone was used for paving the streets and as the primary building material; many of the buildings were lavishly decorated with mosaics.

Originally designed to house around 15,000 people, Timgad rapidly expanded beyond the city walls as it became a trading center, as well as a garrison town, and later, in the 3rd century, an important regional center of Christianity. The Romans were forced out in the 5th century, and the town was ransacked and left uninhabited some 300 years later.

ROMAN GRID PLAN

The rectangular perimeter wall encloses a city constructed with an orthogonal grid plan of streets. The principal streets are the *Decumanus*, which runs east-west through the center of the town, and the *Cardo*, the main road running north-south from the northern entrance to where it meets the *Decumanus* at the Forum in the center of the town.



KEY

- Arches
- Churches and temples
- Baths
- Other buildings



△ TIMGAD THEATER

The theater, cut into the side of a small hill, seats up to 3,500 people and is still used to stage performances. It was largely rebuilt by French archaeologists.



△ DECORATIVE MOSAIC

Mosaics were used to decorate the walls and floors of the limestone buildings, as marble—which the Romans favored—was not available locally.